

Introduction

To understand the civil-military imbalance in Pakistan, one cannot look at a single event; it is a structural issue rooted in our history. Since 1947, the balance of power has tilted heavily toward the military. I view this not just as "military interference" but as a complex interplay where civilian weakness often invited military strength. The "Viceregal tradition" we inherited from the British where the executive is strong and the legislature is weak set the stage for what scholars often call a "praetorian state."

This report discusses how political leadership, external threats, terrorism, bureaucracy and constitutional crises have shaped this relationship.

Factors Shaping the Relationship

Political Leadership:

The primary failure of the civilian side has been the lack of organized, institutionalized political parties. In 1947, the Muslim League was a movement, not a robust party with grassroots structures in the territories that became Pakistan (unlike the Congress party in India).

- **Dynastic & Feudal Politics:** Our political leadership has largely remained dynastic and feudal. Leaders often view the military not as a subordinate institution but as a potential partner to help them topple rival political parties.
- **Crisis of Legitimacy:** When civilian governments fail to deliver basic governance or engage in massive corruption, they lose moral legitimacy. This creates a "vacuum" that the military steps in to fill, often presenting itself as the "savior" of the nation.

External Threats: The "Security State" Narrative

This is perhaps the most significant factor. Pakistan was born in insecurity (1947 partition violence, the Kashmir war and water disputes).

- **India-Centric Defense:** The immediate threat from a much larger neighbor, India, forced Pakistan to prioritize defense over development from day one. This turned Pakistan into a "Security State."

- **Resource Allocation:** Because security was the top priority, the military received the largest chunk of the budget. With money comes power and modernization. While civilian institutions decayed due to lack of funds, the military became the most modern, organized and disciplined institution in the country.

Bureaucratic Intervention:

In the first decade (1947–1958), it wasn't the army ruling directly but the **Bureaucracy**.

- **The Nexus:** Figures like **Ghulam Muhammad** and **Iskander Mirza** were bureaucrats who despised parliamentary democracy. They formed a "nexus" with the military (the Commander-in-Chief Gen. Ayub Khan) to sideline politicians.
- **The Shift:** Eventually, the military took over the bureaucracy. After 1958, the military took the driving seat but the bureaucracy remains a key tool for managing the state, often loyal to whoever holds the "real" power.

Constitutional Challenges: The "Doctrine of Necessity"

Our judicial history has played a negative role in tilting the balance.

- **Legalizing Coups:** Whenever the military intervened the courts validated it using the infamous "**Doctrine of Necessity**" (e.g., Justice Munir's verdict in 1954/1958 and later for Zia and Musharraf).
- **Article 58(2)(b):** During the 1990s this constitutional article allowed Presidents to dissolve assemblies, effectively keeping the Prime Minister under a sword of Damocles controlled by the establishment.
- **Recent Years:** While the 18th Amendment (2010) removed 58(2)(b), legal challenges now manifest as "Judicial Activism" where courts and the establishment often appear to be on the "same page" regarding the accountability of politicians.

Terrorism:

Post-9/11, the dynamics changed. The threat moved from the eastern border (India) to the western border and *inside* our cities.

- **Military's Expanded Role:** Operations like *Zarb-e-Azb* and *Radd-ul-Fasaad* were

necessary to clear militants. However, fighting terrorism requires policing, intelligence and even judicial powers (Military Courts).

- **Apex Committees:** The formation of "Apex Committees" brought military commanders formally into the loop of civilian governance to manage internal security. This normalized the military's involvement in day-to-day administration, blurring the line between civil and military domains.

Are Balanced Relations Achievable?

In my honest opinion, achieving a "textbook" balance where the military is strictly subservient to civilian leadership is **not achievable in the near future**.

Here is why:

1. **The "Hybrid" Reality:** We have evolved into a hybrid regime where the military is a stakeholder in the economy (via organizations like FWO, NLC) and foreign policy (especially regarding India, Afghanistan and the US). They are unlikely to voluntarily cede this space.
2. **Civilian Competence:** Civilians can only reclaim power through **performance**. As long as politicians rely on the establishment to win elections, or fail to fix the economy, they will remain the junior partner. You cannot demand authority; you have to command it through competence.
3. **The Path Forward:** The best we can hope for is a "**functional imbalance**" where civilians manage the economy and service delivery effectively, while consulting the military on security. Over 10–20 years, if civilians govern well and the economy strengthens, the balance may slowly shift back. But right now, the military is the only institution with the organizational capacity to hold the state together during crises.

Conclusion

To conclude, the civil-military imbalance in Pakistan is not just about generals wanting power; it is about the structural failure of political parties, the persistent security threat from India and legal loopholes that validated interventions. Until political parties democratize themselves and the economy stabilizes, the military will remain the dominant player in Pakistan's power corridor.